

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

17 November 2009

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

In its letter dated 27 December 2005 to the Conference of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, the Universal House of Justice referred to the “unrelenting social and political forces” which “continue to uproot people from their homelands and sweep them across continents”. Over the last four years these forces have shown no signs of ebbing. At the same time, many Bahá'í communities are becoming increasingly confident at sharing Bahá'u'lláh's Message with peoples of all backgrounds. They have frequently reported finding considerable receptivity to the Faith within immigrant populations, including among refugees and asylum seekers coming from places, such as Iran, where to be identified as a Bahá'í would entail overt personal risk. The House of Justice has recently reviewed the guidance on teaching the Faith to this latter group, which stated that they must establish permanent residence before they could be eligible for enrolment. We have been asked to convey the decision of the House of Justice that it is now timely for this restriction to be lifted: lack of permanent residence in a country no longer disqualifies anyone from enrolment in the Faith.

Naturally, when considering the possible enrolment of a refugee or asylum seeker from a place where it is unsafe to be a Bahá'í, caution is necessary. It is important that would-be declarants appreciate the implications of their taking such a step, giving thought to how family members will react and the difficulties that may arise if one day they return to their homeland. Moreover, you should be conscious that, in many countries, being a Bahá'í strengthens a claim to refugee status and to the right of residence in the place where an individual has sought asylum. Given this consideration, it is necessary that, in each case, you pause to consider whether a person's desire to register as a Bahá'í has arisen from his or her genuine recognition of the Manifestation of God for today.

Faith is a state of conscience that expresses itself in word and deed. Therefore in order to assess, to the extent that it is possible, the sincerity of an individual's motive, you must consider the degree to which he or she outwardly manifests the inner reality of belief. Factors that would weigh in favour of a positive assessment include, but are not limited to, rectitude of conduct; a plausible account of a seeker's attraction to the Cause; sustained interest in the Faith over time; involvement in the activities of the global Plan; and, perhaps above all, a record of actively encouraging the participation of one's children, whether teenaged or younger, in classes for Bahá'í education. While such judgements cannot be arrived at lightly, you must avoid placing hindrances in the path of those whose enthusiasm for the spiritual truths to which they have been awakened may be dulled by excessively stringent requirements. Clearly, current circumstances require that, when gauging a seeker's purity of motive, you assess the cases of asylum seekers from certain countries with a rigour you would not apply to those of seekers from elsewhere; nevertheless, you should guard against there being too great a disparity between the ways in which the motive of each is considered. Of course, your approach in this area should be implemented in a spirit of learning, thereby allowing, over time, for a rise in your capacity to evaluate, with sensitivity and wisdom, each

unique situation.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]